



On song: Amoj Jacob of Team India hands the baton to Muhammed Ajmal Variyathodi in the Men's 4x400m relay heats during day eight of the World Athletics Championships Budapest 2023 at the National Athletics Centre on August 26, 2023, in Budapest, Hungary. GETTY IMAGES

to 2:58.00. It's like what they say — if you aim for the stars, at least you will land on the moon," Amoj says.

The team has reason to believe it is on track for that steep goal. "If you compare us to where we were last year, I think we are in much better shape. Last year, all of us were coming back from some sort of injury. We were carrying all sorts of aches and pains before the season. This year, we are thankfully not dealing with any sort of injury. We can focus on our training," says Amoj.

Even as they throw themselves into training, the Indian squad has a key date in mind: May 4. That's when they will get a chance to see just how good they are at the World Athletics

Relays in the Bahamas. While their performance at last year's Worlds, Asian Games, and Championships should all but guarantee India a place in the Olympics via the ranking route, the team wants to qualify outright.

"For that, we need to make the final of the World Relays. Making the top eight will be our first goal. After that, we want to medal, and of course, we want to run a sub-three-minute race once again," says Anas.

Alongside its relay goal, the team has individual targets. "Last year was very good from the team's perspective, but we didn't all get our

personal bests. This season, one of our targets will be to get fast. We want all six of us to run under 46 seconds, and maybe some will run under 45 seconds (Anas currently holds the Indian 400m national record of 45.21 seconds). That way, we will have more options in Paris. We might be able to send a fresh team for the qualifiers and another for the final," says Anas.

Amoj wants to get faster during the Olympic season, but if he runs in Paris, he won't focus on his split times. "I just want to make sure that no matter what, I'm going to be the first guy handing over the baton to my teammate," he says.

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